consequences. Dozens of civilians were killed in the ensuing fusillade of artillery. (The doctrine took its name from a Carthaginian general who poisoned himself rather than be captured by the Romans.)

Very little of this filtered through into the Israeli media, however. Israel bars its own journalists from entering Gaza—a sensible enough policy, considering who runs the strip. Some of the older Palestinian affairs correspondents have contacts in Gaza from the days before 2006, when it was under Israeli control. The others rely on wire reports, foreign journalists, and the Arabic-language media. My landlord phoned me once to ask what was happening across the border, because the Israeli media devoted so little time to the subject.

It's not only truth, but also empathy that is among the first casualties of war: people will focus more on their own suffering than the enemy's, and journalists will accommodate them. But the lopsided nature of Israel's war in Gaza, and the entry ban, meant that editors often struggled to fill their newspapers and bulletins. The results could be blackly comic. Channel 10 aired a segment on a kitten rescued by a tank commander from the rubble of eastern Gaza. The confused animal wandered around the broadcast desk for a few minutes, poking its head into the hosts' coffee cups. On Channel 2, there was a tender report about an all-female artillery unit on the border. Young soldiers showed off a collection of donated hair-care products, stenciled their names on mortars, and munched on sushi delivered by one of their brothers, all of this punctuated by the frequent thump of outgoing projectiles.

One morning in late July, I sat down with Gideon Levy, the liberal *Ha'aretz* columnist. We had met during the previous war in a somewhat surreal cafe at Yad Mordechai, the last junction before the Erez crossing into Gaza. It attracts a motley wartime crowd of journalists and soldiers, smoking and filing copy while warplanes roar overhead. Ordinary civilians pull into the adjacent gas station to fill up, and occasionally have to scramble for cover at the sound of artillery fire. (The defense ministry had a spokesman posted there one day to brief reporters over iced coffee.)

Levy has long been among the country's most polarizing media figures—heroic truth-teller to the far left, traitor and propagandist to everyone else—but he spent much of that previous war reporting from the south, without any problems. In 2014, though, we met in his home in a quiet section of north Tel Aviv. A couple of weeks earlier, he had been accosted in